

A Team A/Team B View: China's Military

A: <i>China's Hollow Military</i> by Bates Gill and Michael O'Hanlon	B: <i>China's Military: A Second Opinion</i> by James Lilley and Carl Ford
“ . . . We believe that the recent clamor over China's strategic ambitions is greatly overblown. Most of the Chinese aims that run counter to US interests are in fact not global or ideological but territorial in nature and confined primarily to the islands and waterways to China's south and southeast . . . An enormous gap separates China's military capabilities from its aspirations. The PRC's armed forces are not very good and not getting better very fast. Whatever China's concerns and intentions, its capacity to act upon them in ways inimical to US interests is severely limited, and will remain so for many years . . . The PRC's power projection capabilities, too, are constrained by huge weaknesses—especially in areas such as aerial refueling, electronic warfare, command and control and amphibious and air assault assets. China owns considerably less top-level equipment than medium powers like Japan and Britain; it owns even less than smaller powers such as Italy, South Korea or The Netherlands . . . The resources it devotes to acquiring modern weaponry are akin to those of countries spending \$10-20 billion a year on defense . . .”	“ . . . We think they got it half right. China is no military superpower and will not acquire that status for some years to come. But measured in terms of its capacity to challenge key US allies in East Asia, China's capabilities have grown exponentially . . . By emphasizing direct comparisons between the defense capabilities of the United States and the PRC, the authors create an artificial and misleading construct . . . What the regime gives every indication of striving for is sufficient military clout to achieve its aims in Asia. In the short term, it wishes to intimidate Taiwan sufficiently to bring about unification on Beijing's terms Investments of the sort Beijing is making can mean only one thing: China is determined to improve the PLA's fighting capability. While most nations are reducing defense expenditures in the post-Cold War era, China is one of the few doing the opposite . . . Across the board, the PLA is engaged in a major spending effort to upgrade weapons and equipment and improve its operational capability. According to the Pentagon, these efforts have already enhanced China's ability to project military power . . .”
—Excerpted from journal articles found in <i>The National Interest</i>, Fall and Winter 2000/2001.	